Who Stopped Answering? Pakistani Women and Pew's Trends on the Taliban and the United States, 2009–2015*

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Abstract

In 2012, Pew reported that Pakistani opinion of the United States was "ever more critical," and the coverage it collected on its site ran under headlines like "People in Pakistan really, really don't like the U.S." Two years later, American ratings were "somewhat less negative," extremist groups were seen negatively "but less so in recent years," and views of the Taliban had "not changed substantially." A newspaper added that a third of Pakistanis were "reluctant" to give their views of the Taliban. Read together, these describe a public whose mood toward America and militants turns every couple of years. Respondent-level data from Pew's seven surveys of Pakistan between 2009 and 2015 show something else. Pakistani men's views of the Taliban and the United States changed little. What moved was how many women answered at all: women declining to rate the United States went from 26% to 12% to 48% and back to 22%, while men stayed between 6 and 10%. The same women declined to rate the Taliban, al Qaeda, China, and Iran, so the "reluctance" was not about the Taliban. Women were interviewed by women, and their non-response varied across interviewers far more than chance allows. Neither education, coverage, nor a change in Pew's questions explains the swings, and no other country Pew surveyed shows a rise confined to women. Much of the reported change in Pakistani opinion is a change in who answered.

1 Introduction

In June 2012, Pew titled its Pakistan report "Pakistani Public Opinion Ever More Critical of U.S." (Pew Research Center, 2012a); coverage that Pew archived on its site ran under headlines like "People in Pakistan really, really don't like the U.S." (Pew Research Center, 2012b). By August 2014, the same public had warmed: Pew's Pakistan report carried a section titled "U.S. Ratings Somewhat Less Negative" and a chart titled "Extremists Seen Negatively, but Less So in Recent Years" (Pew Research Center, 2014b). A month earlier, Pew's report on extremism had found that "views of the Taliban have not changed substantially in recent years," with "a third of Pakistanis not offering an opinion" (Pew Research Center, 2014a). *Dawn* explained the third: they were "reluctant to offer an opinion" (Iqbal, 2014).

Taken at face value, these reports describe a public that grew angrier at the United States and then calmer within two years, softened toward extremists while holding steady on the Taliban, and

*https://github.com/finite-sample/pew-pakistan-nonresponse.

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kept its views of the Taliban to itself. Opinion can move, but these claims are hard to reconcile with one another. Trying to reconcile them is how this note began.

The respondent-level files resolve the puzzle without any change in opinion. Pakistani men's answers were stable from 2009 to 2015. Women's non-response swung by twenty points or more from one year to the next, on questions about every foreign actor and militant group, and the same women declined across topics. Because most women who answer are unfavorable, more of them answering makes Pakistan look angrier, and fewer makes it look calmer. The reported trends average a stable male series with a female series whose set of answerers changes from year to year. None of these reports discusses non-response by sex.

2 Data

I use Pew's respondent-level files for the seven Spring Global Attitudes surveys from 2009 to 2015 (Pew Research Center, 2014c). Pakistan is not in Pew's spring surveys after 2015. Every Pakistan survey was conducted face to face with adults, using a multi-stage area probability sample stratified by province and urbanity that oversampled cities and was weighted back to the national urban share. Samples were about 2,000 in 2010 and 2011 and about 1,200 in the other years. Coverage was about 90% of adults in 2009 and about 82% from 2012 on, when more insecure areas of Khyber Pakhtunkhwa and Balochistan were excluded along with the tribal areas, Gilgit-Baltistan, and Azad Kashmir.

Each answer is coded as positive (very or somewhat favorable; often or sometimes justified; a very or somewhat serious threat), negative, or no answer (don't know or refused). All shares use Pew's weights. Standard errors use the Kish effective sample size, inflated by the design effect implied by Pew's stated margin of error for Pakistan in each year (for 2015, which the released files do not state, I use the 2014 figure); for a change in women's no-answer share between two years, they are about 4 percentage points. The weighted estimates match Pew's published 2014 figures to within a point: 8% favorable and 59% unfavorable toward the Taliban, 11% favorable toward al Qaeda, and 3% saying suicide bombing is often or sometimes justified.

3 Women's Non-Response Swings; Men's Does Not

Table 1 reports the share giving no answer in each year. For men, it is stable for nearly every item: between 6 and 10% for the United States, 2 and 5% for China, and 8 and 15% for the Taliban. For women, it moves by large amounts from one survey to the next. On the United States, it fell from 26% in 2010 to 12% in 2012, rose to 48% in 2014, and fell back to 22% in 2015. China, Iran, the Taliban, and al Qaeda move with it. The 2014 peak, then, was not the start of a trend; the next survey reversed most of it. Domestic politicians are the exception: almost every woman rated Nawaz Sharif in every year except 2013, when the survey was fielded two months before the election that returned him to office.

Table 1: Share giving no answer, Pakistan, by sex and year

	2009	2010	2011	2012	2013	2014	2015
Women: United States	26	26	21	12	27	48	22
Women: China	23	23	18	16	31	37	22
Women: Iran	34	34	30	27	40	50	38
Women: Taliban	25	29	37	32	35	53	33
Women: al Qaeda	41	42	50	46	56	69	59
Women: Nawaz Sharif	5	8	6	3	15	7	6
Men: United States	7	6	7	6	6	8	10
Men: China	4	2	4	5	2	3	4
Men: Iran	3	5	7	5	10	9	16
Men: Taliban	15	9	10	8	12	14	12
Men: al Qaeda	20	16	19	17	26	25	32
Men: Nawaz Sharif	2	4	2	1	1	1	1

Weighted percentages of respondents answering don't know or refusing a favorability question.

4 The Same Women

The women who decline one question are the women who decline the others (Table 2). In 2014, 69% of women who gave no answer about the Taliban also gave none about the United States, against 24% of women who rated the Taliban. The share of women who answered none of five questions (the Taliban, al Qaeda, the United States, China, and Iran) rose from 8% in 2009 to 28% in 2014 and fell to 11% in 2015. Among men it never exceeded 1%. Non-response here is a property of respondents, not of the Taliban question. Calling it reluctance to talk about the Taliban, as *Dawn* did, attributes to one question what the same women did on all of them.

Table 2: Non-response across questions, by respondent

	Women: all five	US | skipped Taliban	US | answered	Men: all five	US | skipped Taliban	US | answered
2009	8	53	17	0	13	6
2010	12	55	14	0	23	4
2011	9	42	9	1	14	6
2012	5	20	8	0	12	5
2013	14	46	17	0	17	4
2014	28	69	24	1	17	6
2015	11	46	11	1	27	7

Weighted percentages. "All five" is the share giving no answer about the Taliban, al Qaeda, the United States, China, and Iran. The other columns give the share without an answer about the United States among those who did and did not answer about the Taliban.

5 The Reported Trends Move With It

Most women who answer give an unfavorable rating, so more women answering raises the unfavorable share and fewer lowers it. Table 3 shows the result for the two series Pew highlighted. Unfavorable views of the United States peaked at 80% in 2012, the year Pew called opinion "ever

more critical," and fell to 59% in 2014, the year Pew called ratings "somewhat less negative." Among men, the same series went from 78% in 2009 to 85% in 2012 and 80% in 2014: a rise in 2011, then little change. Among women, it went from 74% in 2012 to 37% in 2014 as their non-response quadrupled. About half of the 2012 peak and nearly all of the 2014 decline come from women.

The Taliban series has the same structure. Men's unfavorable share was 74% in 2009, 75% in 2014, and 81% in 2015. Women's fell from 66% to 42%, nearly all of it to no answer (Table 4), and returned to 63% in 2015 as their non-response fell. The full sample went from 59% unfavorable in 2014 to 72% in 2015, a thirteen-point hardening against the Taliban that, like the softening before it, comes almost entirely from women answering. Al Qaeda is partly different. Men's favorable share rose from 8% to 15% and their unfavorable share fell from 72% to 60%, so for al Qaeda, Pew's "less so in recent years" describes something real among men.

Table 3: Unfavorable views, Pakistan, by sex and year

	2009	2010	2011	2012	2013	2014	2015
United States	68	68	75	80	72	59	61
Women	57	57	63	74	60	37	49
Men	78	78	85	85	83	80	73
Taliban	70	66	66	67	65	59	72
Women	66	59	53	54	53	42	63
Men	74	73	78	78	77	75	81

Weighted percentages very or somewhat unfavorable, with respondents giving no answer in the denominator, as Pew reports them.

Table 4: Favorable, unfavorable, and no answer, Pakistan, 2009 and 2014

	Fav. 2009	Unfav.	No answer	Fav. 2014	Unfav.	No answer
Taliban	10	70	20	8	59	33
Women	9	66	25	5	42	53
Men	11	74	15	11	75	14
al Qaeda	9	61	30	11	42	46
Women	11	49	41	7	23	69
Men	8	72	20	15	60	25
United States	16	68	16	14	59	27
Women	16	57	26	16	37	48
Men	15	78	7	12	80	8

Weighted percentages. Rows may not sum to 100 because of rounding.

6 Not a Change in Who Was Sampled

The 2014 sample contains more women without formal schooling than the 2009 sample (49% and 61%), and women without schooling answer less often. That accounts for little of the change (Table 5). Women's no-answer share on the Taliban rose within both groups, from 37% to 62% among women without schooling and from 13% to 40% among women with some. Holding 2014 at the 2009 education mix gives 51%, against 53% observed. Coverage cannot explain the swings either: it was the same from 2012 to 2014, when the largest swings occurred, and excluding districts removes men and women alike.

Table 5: No answer by schooling, Pakistan, 2009 and 2014

	None 2009	None 2014	Some 2009	Some 2014	All 2009	All 2014	2014, 2009 mix
Women: Taliban	37	62	13	40	25	53	51
Women: al Qaeda	51	76	31	59	41	69	67
Women: United States	37	60	16	31	26	49	45
Women: China	36	50	10	19	23	38	34
Men: Taliban	27	19	11	12	15	14	14
Men: al Qaeda	38	34	13	20	20	25	24
Men: United States	14	12	5	6	7	8	8
Men: China	12	5	0	2	4	3	3

Weighted percentages giving no answer. "None" is no formal education; "some" is any schooling. The last column applies 2014 rates within each group to the 2009 education mix. Respondents with missing education are excluded.

7 Not a Change in Pew's Questionnaire

If Pew had changed how it asked these questions, women's non-response would have moved elsewhere too. Table 6 reports the change from 2009 to 2014 in non-response to the question about the United States, asked in every country in both years. In most of the 23 countries, women's and men's no-answer shares moved together by a few points. India and Nigeria show large rises, but for men as well. On the United States, the gap between the rise among women and the rise among men is +21 points in Pakistan; the next largest is +12 in India. The question about China gives the same result: a gap of +15 points in Pakistan, and at most +7 elsewhere (Mexico).

8 Interviewers

Two of the seven files identify interviewers, and one records their sex. In 2010, 99% of women were interviewed by women and nearly every man by a man, so women's answers come from a separate team of interviewers. Women's non-response varies across interviewers much more than sampling alone would produce (Table 7). For the question about the United States in 2010, the variance across female interviewers is about 8 times what chance would give; across male interviewers, about 2 times. For the Taliban, the excess is large for both. Interviewers work in particular places, so these figures combine interviewer and area. They show that whether a woman answers depends

Table 6: Change in no answer, 2009 to 2014, by country and sex

Item	Country	Women	Men
United States	India	+28	+16
	Pakistan	+22	+1
	Nigeria	+16	+10
	Kenya	+6	+0
	Brazil	+5	−1
	Palestinian Territories	+4	+0
	Indonesia	+2	+0
	Mexico	+2	+1
	Argentina	+2	+0
	Japan	+2	−1
	Lebanon	+1	+0
	United States	+1	+0
	Jordan	+1	+4
	France	+0	+0
	Germany	+0	−1
	Egypt	−1	+3
	China	−2	+1
	Israel	−2	−2
	Poland	−3	+0
	South Korea	−4	+0
	Russia	−5	−7
	Spain	−8	−7
	Turkey	−14	−3

Percentage-point changes in the weighted share giving no answer to favorability of the United States. Countries surveyed on the item in both years with at least 150 respondents of each sex.

heavily on who interviews her and where, which is what the series would look like if the female interviewing team changed from year to year.

Table 7: No-answer rates across interviewers, 2009 and 2010

Item	Year	Respondents	Interviewers	Range (%)	Variance / chance
Taliban	2009	Women	25	0–84	5.6
	2009	Men	25	0–95	8.5
	2010	Women	37	0–80	7.0
	2010	Men	38	0–86	6.2
United States	2009	Women	25	0–70	4.3
	2009	Men	25	0–70	5.6
	2010	Women	37	0–75	7.6
	2010	Men	38	0–36	1.8

Interviewers with at least ten respondents of the given sex. Range is the lowest and highest interviewer-level share giving no answer. The last column divides the variance of those shares by the variance expected from sampling alone.

Not every high rate of non-response is this pattern. In 2015, Pew asked Pakistanis about ISIS: 10% were favorable, 28% unfavorable, and 62% gave no answer. Here men gave no answer too (50%, against 74% of women), though only 12% of men skipped the Taliban question in the same survey. ISIS was a group many Pakistanis had not formed a view of. That did not stop the favorable share from traveling: at the 2016 Republican National Convention, Newt Gingrich cited it as "just 9 percent of Muslims in Pakistan view ISIS favorably … that 9 percent is 16 million people" (Greenberg, 2016). A favorable rating of a group most respondents had no view of is a weak measure of support.

9 What the Data Cannot Say

The files from 2011 on do not identify interviewers, so the cause of any one year's swing cannot be pinned down. The candidates are changes in fieldwork that bear on women: who was hired and how they were trained, whether male household members were present, and changes of fieldwork firm. Interviewer characteristics are known to shift answers in surveys in Muslim-majority countries (Benstead, 2014), and women are less likely than men to guess when a don't-know option is available (Mondak and Anderson, 2004), which makes their answers more sensitive to how that option is offered.

The data also cannot say what the women who did not answer think. What they show is that year-to-year changes in Pakistan's aggregate numbers on the Taliban and the United States mostly measure changes in who answered.

10 Implications

The Pakistani series on militant groups and the United States should be read separately by sex. Men are a stable series: between 2009 and 2015, their unfavorable views of the Taliban barely moved,

their unfavorable views of the United States rose in 2011 and stayed high, and their views of al Qaeda softened. Women are not a stable series, and their answers change mostly in whether they are given. Pew could report non-response by sex alongside its trend lines; the swings documented here are visible in a single cross-tabulation for each year.

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